

HISTORY HACK · DOCUMENT-BASED QUESTION

The Road to War — American Neutrality and Entry into World War I, 1914–1917

US.26 — Explain the reasons for U.S. entry into World War I, including the use of unrestricted submarine warfare, the Zimmerman Telegram, the defense of democracy, and economic motivations.

US.27 — Identify and explain the impact of the following on World War I (T.C.A. § 49-6-1006): • Trench warfare • Use of new weapons and technology • John J. Pershing • Harlem Hell Fighters • Alvin C. York

TEACHER EDITION — scoring guide and expected evidence. Not for student distribution.

Name _____ Class _____ Date _____

Directions. Read the three documents below. Then write a well-organized essay addressing the following question: To what extent was U.S. entry into World War I in April 1917 a response to deliberate foreign provocation versus a product of the United States' own prior choices and entanglements? Your essay must: — Apply SOAPS analysis to at least two documents — Use evidence from all three documents — Incorporate outside knowledge of U.S. neutrality policy 1914–1917 — Construct a clear, defensible argument

The sources

Document 1

The Zimmermann Telegram, January 16, 1917 — U.S. National Archives, public domain (decoded and released by British intelligence to the U.S. State Department, February 24, 1917)

“We intend to begin on the first of February unrestricted submarine warfare. We shall endeavor in spite of this to keep the United States of America neutral. In the event of this not succeeding, we make Mexico the following offer to alliance on the following basis: make war together, make peace together, generous financial support and an understanding on our part that Mexico is to reconquer the lost territory in Texas, New Mexico, and Arizona. The settlement in detail is left to you. You will inform the President of the above most secretly as soon as the outbreak of war with the United States is certain...” — Arthur Zimmermann, German Foreign Secretary”

SOURCE IT — DOCUMENT 1

H — Historical context

What was happening when
this was made?

I — Intended audience

Who was meant to read or
hear it?

P — Purpose

What was it trying to make
the audience do or think?

P — Point of view

Who is speaking, and how
does that shape it?

Document 2

President Woodrow Wilson, Address to Congress Requesting Declaration of War, April 2, 1917 —
Bryan, William Jennings, ed., Republic or Empire (1899), public domain, public domain

“The present German submarine warfare against commerce is a warfare against mankind. It is a war against all nations. American ships have been sunk, American lives taken, in ways which it has stirred us very deeply to learn of, but the ships and people of other neutral and friendly nations have been sunk and overwhelmed in the waters in the same way. There has been no discrimination. The challenge is to all mankind.”

SOURCE IT — DOCUMENT 2

H — Historical context

What was happening when this was made?

I — Intended audience

Who was meant to read or hear it?

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What was it trying to make the audience do or think?

P — Point of view

Who is speaking, and how does that shape it?

Document 3

Senator George Norris of Nebraska, Speech Opposing U.S. Declaration of War, April 4, 1917 — Bryan, William Jennings, ed., Republic or Empire (1899), public domain, public domain

“We are going into war upon the command of gold... I feel that we are about to put the dollar sign on the American flag... I am confident that the object of the President, in asking for war, is to serve the wealthy interests of our country and not the plain people... I think we should wait patiently until the American people are willing to go into war for their country rather than for the bankers.”

SOURCE IT — DOCUMENT 3

H — Historical context

What was happening when
this was made?

I — Intended audience

Who was meant to read or
hear it?

P — Purpose

What was it trying to make
the audience do or think?

P — Point of view

Who is speaking, and how
does that shape it?

The question

DOCUMENT 3 Senator George Norris of Nebraska, Speech Opposing U.S. Declaration of War, April 4, 1917 — Bryan, William Jennings, ed., Republic or Empire (1899), public domain, public domain: "We are going into war upon the command of gold... I feel that we are about to put the dollar sign on the American flag... I am confident that the object of the President, in asking for war, is to serve the wealthy interests of our country and not the plain people... I think we should wait patiently until the American people are willing to go into war for their country rather than for the bankers."

Plan your answer

Your claim	
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Source	Evidence you will use	Why it supports your claim
Document 1		
Document 2		
Document 3		
Outside knowledge		

Write your response

Scoring guide

Pts	6-point scale
6	Exemplary. Complex thesis addressing both foreign provocation AND American entanglement/prior choices. SOAPS of at least two documents accurately — especially distinguishing Zimmermann's purpose (create Mexican diversion) from its significance (outraged U.S. public) and Norris's purpose (oppose war) from his significance (economic critique of U.S. 'neutrality'). Extensive outside knowledge. Cross-document synthesis showing Documents 1 and 2 support one side while Document 3 challenges it.
5	Advanced. Clear thesis. SOAPS of at least two documents. Good outside knowledge. Addresses both sides of the question but may not fully develop the cross-document tension.
4	Proficient. Clear thesis. Uses all three documents. SOAPS of at least one document. Some outside knowledge. Coherent argument.
3	Adequate. Thesis present. Uses two or more documents. Some SOAPS elements. Limited outside knowledge.
2	Developing. Weak thesis. Uses documents without SOAPS analysis.
1	Beginning. No thesis. Minimal document use.
0	No response or completely off-topic.

Expected evidence and document analysis. DOCUMENT ANALYSIS EXPECTATIONS: — Doc 1 (Zimmermann): Note Germany assumed war with the U.S. was coming — this shows German intentions clearly; audience is Mexico via German ambassador; significance = decoded by British, released to shift U.S. opinion. — Doc 2 (Wilson): Note 'warfare against mankind' universalizes the cause; avoids mentioning economic entanglement; purpose = justify war in the most defensible terms possible. — Doc 3 (Norris): Note explicit accusation that financial interests drove policy; this is an argument about American agency and prior choices, not German provocation; significance = anticipates Nye Committee revisionism. KEY EVIDENCE EXPECTED: U.S. loans to Allies; Lusitania (May 7, 1915, 1,198 dead); Sussex Pledge (1916); Germany's renewed unrestricted warfare announcement (January 31, 1917); Zimmermann decoded (February 1917), published (March 1, 1917); Wilson's 1916 'He kept us out of war' campaign; April 6, 1917 declaration; six senators against (including Norris and La Follette); Nye Committee (1934) — revisionist view validating Norris's argument.

Sourcing. Every document above carries its own citation as written in the item record. Verify each against the holding institution before classroom use — an unsourced primary source is worse than a missing one.

